Chapter 8 — Modules, Packages and Environments

A single file is fine for a script. Real programs are spread across many files, depend on code other people wrote (NumPy, requests, Django), and must run the same way on your laptop, a colleague's machine and a server. This chapter covers the three layers that make that possible:

1. **Modules and packages** — how Python code is split into files and folders and pulled together with `import`.
2. **The import system** — where Python looks for code, what it caches, and why imports sometimes fail.
3. **Environments and packaging** — `pip`, virtual environments, `requirements.txt` vs `pyproject.toml`, modern tools (`uv`, Poetry), project layout and publishing to PyPI.

All scripts are in `code/`; they build their demo packages in temporary folders, so they leave nothing behind. Output shown is real (Python 3.14; code is 3.12-compatible).

What you'll learn

#	Topic	Script
8.1	Modules and the four `import` forms, aliases	`01_import_basics.py`
8.2	How `import` works: `sys.modules`, finders/loaders, `sys.path`	`01_import_basics.py`, `02_packages_and_sys_path.py`
8.3	Packages, `__init__.py`, namespace packages, `__all__`	`02_packages_and_sys_path.py`
8.4	Absolute vs relative imports	`02_packages_and_sys_path.py`
8.5	`if __name__ == "__main__"` and `python -m`	`02_packages_and_sys_path.py`
8.6	Common import errors, circular imports	`03_import_errors.py`
8.7	`pip` and virtual environments (`venv`)	`04_environments.py`
8.8	`requirements.txt` vs `pyproject.toml`; `uv` and Poetry	`04_environments.py`
8.9	Project layout (src layout) and publishing basics	—

8.1 Modules and `import`

What it is

A **module** is simply a `.py` file of Python code — functions, classes, variables — that other code can load with `import`. The module's name is the file name without `.py` (`pricing.py` → module `pricing`). Modules can also be compiled extensions (`.so`/`.pyd`, e.g. parts of NumPy) or be built into the interpreter (`sys`).

Python ships with a large **standard library** ("batteries included"): `math`, `json`, `pathlib`, `datetime`, `random`, `csv`, `sqlite3`, `http`, `unittest` and a few hundred more — file handling, networking, data formats, testing, concurrency — available with no installation.

Analogy: modules are the chapters of a manual; `import` is putting a bookmark in one so you can refer to it.

Why it matters

- **Organisation** — big programs become small files with one theme each.

- **Reuse and sharing** — the same module can serve many programs; the whole PyPI ecosystem is modules.
- **Namespaces** — each module has its own global namespace, so `json.load` and `pickle.load` never collide.

How it works — the four import forms

Form	You then write	Brings into your namespace
`import math`	`math.sqrt(81)`	The name `math` (the module)
`from math import sqrt`	`sqrt(64)`	Only the name `sqrt`
`import numpy as np`	`np.array(...)`	The module under an **alias**
`from math import sqrt as square_root`	`square_root(2)`	One name under an alias

```
import math                                 # whole module
import math as m                            # module with an alias
from math import sqrt                       # one name
from math import sqrt as square_root        # one name with an alias
from os import path as os_path

print("math.sqrt(81)       =", math.sqrt(81))
print("sqrt(64)            =", sqrt(64))
print("square_root(m.pi)   =", square_root(m.pi))
print("m is math           =", m is math)
```

Output:

```
== four import forms ==
math.sqrt(81)       = 9.0
sqrt(64)            = 8.0
square_root(m.pi)   = 1.7724538509055159
m is math           = True
os_path.join('a','b') = a/b

== a module is an object with a namespace ==
sys   type=module  compiled into the interpreter
json  type=module  file ending __init__.py
names in math starting with 'is': ['isclose', 'isfinite', 'isinf', 'isnan', 'isqrt']
```

- A dotted name after `import` (`math.sqrt`) uses **dot notation** to reach attributes inside the module.
- An **alias** (`as`) shortens long names (`np`, `pd`, `plt` are near-universal conventions) or avoids a clash (two modules both exporting `load`).
- `m is math` is `True`: an alias is just a second name for the **same** module object.
- `dir(module)` lists what's inside; `help(module)` shows its documentation.
- `json` reports `__init__.py` — it's actually a *package* (8.3).

`from module import *` copies every public name (or those listed in `__all__`) into your namespace. PEP 8 discourages it outside interactive sessions: readers can't tell where names came from and it can silently overwrite your own names.

Style (PEP 8): imports at the top of the file, one per line, grouped *standard library → third-party → your own code*, separated by blank lines. Tools like `ruff` and `isort` sort them automatically.

Trade-offs

	`import math`	`from math import sqrt`
Clarity at call site	`math.sqrt` shows origin	`sqrt` is shorter but origin is hidden
Name clashes	None	Possible
Circular-import safety	Safer (attribute looked up at call time, 8.6)	Riskier
Monkey-patching/mocking	Sees patched attributes	Holds the *old* object

Common mistakes

- Naming your own file after a module you want to use (`random.py`, `json.py`, `email.py`) — see 8.6.
- `import math.sqrt` → `ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'math.sqrt'; 'math' is not a package`. `import` names modules; use `from math import sqrt` for functions.
- Wildcard imports in production code.

Real-world examples

Every data-science notebook starts with `import numpy as np`, `import pandas as pd`, `import matplotlib.pyplot as plt` — community-standard aliases. Django projects import from their own apps: `from shop.models import Order`.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A module is a `.py` file; `import m` loads it once and binds the name `m`, and `from m import x` binds just `x`. `as` gives an alias. Prefer explicit imports, avoid `import *`, and group imports stdlib/third-party/local."

- *Difference between `import a` and `from a import b`?* → Both load the whole module `a`; they differ only in which name is bound in your namespace.
- *Does importing twice run the module twice?* → No — the second time it's fetched from `sys.modules` (8.2).

Self-check

1. What is a module? → A file of Python code that can be imported.
2. After `from math import sqrt`, does `math.pi` work? → No — `math` isn't bound.
3. Why use `import numpy as np`? → Shorter, conventional alias.

TL;DR

Module = file. `import m` / `from m import x` / `as` aliases. Explicit imports, grouped, at the top.

8.2 How `import` really works

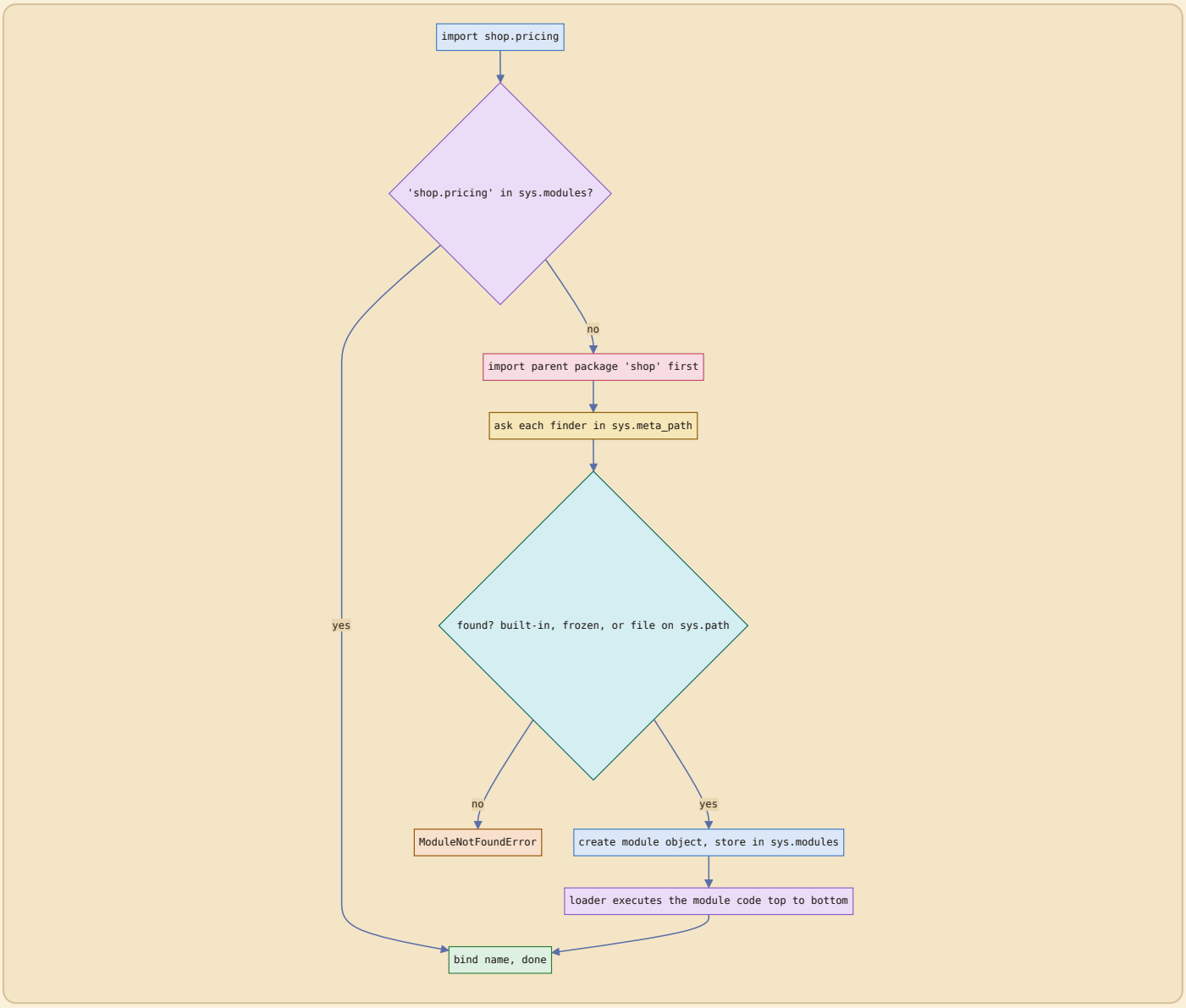
What it is

The **import system** is the machinery that turns `import shop.pricing` into a module object. Three pieces matter:

- **`sys.modules`** — a dict cache of every module already loaded, keyed by full name.

- **Finders and loaders** — *finders* (listed in `sys.meta_path`) locate a module; a *loader* creates and executes it. The built-in chain handles built-in modules, frozen modules and the file system.
- `sys.path` — the list of folders the file-system finder searches, in order.

How it works



1. **Check the cache.** If the name is in `sys.modules`, reuse that object — module code runs **only once per process**. (`importlib.reload(m)` forces a re-run; rarely needed outside interactive work.)
2. **Import parents first.** `import a.b.c` imports `a`, then `a.b`, then `a.b.c`.
3. **Find.** Each finder is asked in turn. The path finder walks `sys.path`, which is built as:
    1. the folder of the script being run (or the current directory for `python -m` / `python -c` / the REPL),
    2. folders in the `PYTHONPATH` environment variable,
    3. the standard library,
    4. `site-packages` — where `pip` installs third-party packages (the active venv's, if one is active).
4. **Load.** A new module object is created and put into `sys.modules` **before** its code runs (this is why circular imports give half-built modules, 8.6), then its top-level code executes, filling its namespace.
5. **Bind** the requested name(s) in the importing namespace.

Compiled bytecode is cached in `__pycache__/*.pyc` files so later imports skip re-parsing; that's why those folders appear. They're safe to delete and belong in `.gitignore`.

```
print("'math' in sys.modules:", "math" in sys.modules)
again = importlib.import_module("math")
print("second import returns the same object:", again is math)
json_mod = importlib.import_module("json")     # import by string name
```

```
'math' in sys.modules: True
second import returns the same object: True
json.dumps via import_module: {"a": 1}
```

`importlib.import_module("name")` imports by a string — how plugin systems and frameworks (Django's `INSTALLED_APPS`) load modules chosen in configuration.

Common mistakes

- Fixing "module not found" with `sys.path.append(...)` hacks scattered through code. Install the project instead (`pip install -e .`, 8.9) or run with `python -m` from the project root.
- Expecting edits to a module to show up in a running REPL/notebook without `importlib.reload` (or Jupyter's `%autoreload`).

In the interview

30-second answer: "`import` first checks `sys.modules`; if missing, finders search built-ins and then the folders in `sys.path` — script directory, PYTHONPATH, stdlib, site-packages. The loader creates the module, registers it in `sys.modules`, then runs its top-level code once. Later imports reuse the cached object."

- *Why does module-level code only run once?* → The module is cached in `sys.modules`.
- *What's `__pycache__`?* → Cached bytecode (`.pyc`) to speed up later imports.
- *In what order is `sys.path` searched?* → Script dir, PYTHONPATH, stdlib, site-packages; first match wins.

Self-check

1. Where does Python cache loaded modules? → `sys.modules`.
2. Which folder comes first in `sys.path` when you run `python app.py`? → The folder containing `app.py`.
3. How can you import a module whose name is in a string? → `importlib.import_module`.

TL;DR

Cache (`sys.modules`) → find (`sys.meta_path`, `sys.path`) → load (register, then execute once) → bind. First match on `sys.path` wins.

8.3 Packages, `__init__.py`, namespace packages, `__all__`

What it is

A **package** is a folder of modules that can be imported as a unit, giving a hierarchy of dotted names (`shop.pricing`, `sklearn.linear_model`). Technically a package is a module with a `__path__` attribute (the list of folders to search for its submodules).

- **Regular package**: a folder containing `__init__.py`. That file runs the first time the package (or anything inside it) is imported. It can be empty, or it can define the package's public API by re-exporting names, set `__version__`, etc.
- **Namespace package** (PEP 420, Python 3.3+): a folder *without* `__init__.py`. Python still imports it; several folders on `sys.path` can even contribute to one namespace (used by big organisations to split one namespace across separately-installed distributions). It has no `__file__`.

	Module	Regular package	Namespace package
On disk	`x.py`	folder + `__init__.py`	folder, no `__init__.py`
Has `__path__`	No	Yes	Yes
Runs code on import	The file	`__init__.py`	Nothing
Use for	Single unit	Normal libraries and apps	Splitting one namespace over several installs

`__all__` is an optional list of strings in a module or `__init__.py`: it defines what `from package import *` exports and documents the public API.

How it works — the demo package

`02_packages_and_sys_path.py` writes this tree into a temporary folder:

```
shop/
    __init__.py      # from .pricing import price_with_tax ; __all__ ; __version__
    __main__.py      # makes "python -m shop" work
    pricing.py       # uses a relative and an absolute import of utils
    utils.py
plugins/             # no __init__.py -> namespace package
    extra.py
```

```python
# shop/__init__.py
"""shop - a tiny demo package."""
from .pricing import price_with_tax      # re-export the public API
__all__ = ["price_with_tax"]
__version__ = "0.1.0"
print(f"  [running shop/__init__.py, __name__={__name__!r}]")
```

Then it adds the temp folder to `sys.path` and imports:

```python
sys.path.insert(0, str(root))
import shop                          # runs shop/__init__.py once
import shop                          # cached: __init__ does NOT run again
from shop import price_with_tax
```

```
== import it: put its parent folder on sys.path ==
  [running shop/__init__.py, __name__='shop']
  price_with_tax(100) = 108.0
  shop.__version__    = 0.1.0
  shop.__path__ is a list of folders: ['shop']
  pricing.__name__    = shop.pricing | __package__ = shop
  namespace package: extra plugin (namespace package, no __init__.py)
  plugins has __file__? None

== star import only takes names in __all__ ==
  names brought in: ['price_with_tax']
```

The `[running shop/__init__.py…]` line appears once despite two `import shop` statements. Users can write `from shop import price_with_tax` without knowing it lives in `shop/pricing.py` — the `__init__.py` "facade" is how `pandas` lets you write `pd.DataFrame` although `DataFrame` is defined deep in `pandas/core/frame.py`.

Trade-offs

A heavy `__init__.py` that imports every submodule makes `import pkg` slow and raises circular-import risk; an empty one forces users to know the internal layout. Common middle ground: re-export the small public API, keep the rest internal (by convention, `_private` names and modules).

When not to use it

Don't rely on namespace packages for your ordinary project — forgetting `__init__.py` "works" but tools (some test runners, type checkers, packaging configs) handle regular packages more predictably. Use namespace packages deliberately.

Common mistakes

- Putting slow work (network calls, loading big files) at top level of `__init__.py`.
- Assuming `import pkg` also imports all submodules — it doesn't, unless `__init__.py` imports them. `import pkg.sub` is needed.

Real-world examples

- `sklearn` is a package of subpackages: `from sklearn.linear_model import LogisticRegression`.
- `json`, `email`, `http`, `urllib`, `concurrent` are packages in the standard library.
- Google's cloud client libraries share the `google.cloud` namespace package across separately installed distributions (`google-cloud-storage`, `google-cloud-bigquery`).

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A package is a folder of modules; with `__init__.py` it's a regular package whose init file runs on first import and usually re-exports the public API. Without it, it's a PEP 420 namespace package that can span multiple folders. `__all__` controls `import *` and documents the public surface."

- *Is `__init__.py` required in Python 3?* → No, but without it you get a namespace package, which behaves differently; use it for normal packages.
- *What does `__all__` do?* → Lists names exported by `from m import *`.

Self-check

1. How does Python tell a package from a module? → A package has `__path__`.
2. When does `__init__.py` run? → On the first import of the package or any of its submodules.
3. Does `import shop` import `shop.utils`? → Only if `shop/__init__.py` (or something it imports) does.

TL;DR

Package = folder of modules (+ `__init__.py` for a regular package). `__init__.py` runs once and defines the public API. `__all__` limits `import *`.

8.4 Absolute vs relative imports

What it is

- **Absolute import**: names the full path from a top-level package on `sys.path` — `from shop.utils import round_money`.
- **Relative import**: names a location relative to the *current package* using leading dots — `from .utils import round_money` (same package), `from ..core import x` (parent package). Only the `from … import …` form can be relative.

How it works

Relative imports are resolved using the module's `__package__` (`'shop'` for `shop.pricing`, shown in the output above). A file run directly as a script has `__name__ == "__main__"` and no parent package, so relative imports inside it fail:

```
python shop/pricing.py  -> ImportError: attempted relative import with no known parent package
python -m shop.pricing  ->
  [running shop/__init__.py, __name__='shop']
  pricing run directly: 10 -> 10.8
  stderr: RuntimeWarning: 'shop.pricing' found in sys.modules after import of package 'shop', but
prior to execution of 'shop.pricing'; this may result in unpredictable behaviour
```

Running with `python -m shop.pricing` from the project root works because Python imports the package first. The `RuntimeWarning` is a real gotcha worth knowing: `shop/__init__.py` already imported `shop.pricing`, so `-m` then executes a *second* copy of it as `__main__`. The fix is to keep runnable entry points in modules that the package `__init__` doesn't import (such as `__main__.py` or a `cli.py`).

Trade-offs

	Absolute	Relative
Readability	Full origin visible	Short inside deep packages
Moving/renaming the top package	Must edit imports	Keeps working
Works in a script run directly	Yes (if package is on `sys.path`)	No
PEP 8	**Recommended**	Acceptable for intra-package imports

Python 2's *implicit* relative imports (`import utils` meaning "sibling module") no longer exist in Python 3 — a bare `import utils` is always absolute.

Common mistakes

- Running a module inside a package as `python pkg/mod.py` → relative imports fail; use `python -m pkg.mod`.
- Too many dots (`from ...x`) beyond the top-level package → `ImportError: attempted relative import beyond top-level package`.

In the interview

30-second answer: "Absolute imports use the full dotted path and are PEP 8's default; relative imports use dots relative to the current package and work only inside packages, not in files run as scripts — run those with `python -m`."

Self-check

1. What does `from . import utils` mean? → Import `utils` from the current package.
2. Why does a relative import fail in `python pkg/mod.py`? → The module is `__main__` with no parent package.

TL;DR

Absolute by default; dots for intra-package imports; run package modules with `python -m`.

8.5 `if __name__ == "__main__":` and `python -m`

What it is

Every module has a `__name__`. When the file is **imported**, `__name__` is its module name (`'shop.pricing'`). When the file is **run directly** (`python file.py` or `python -m pkg.mod`), `__name__` is the string `'__main__'`. The guard

```
if __name__ == "__main__":
    main()
```

runs code only when the file is executed, not when it's imported.

Why it matters

It lets one file be both a **reusable module** and a **runnable script**: tests and other modules can import its functions without triggering the script behaviour (starting a server, parsing command-line arguments, printing). It's also required for code using `multiprocessing` on platforms that start workers by re-importing the main module (the `spawn` and `forkserver` start methods: Windows, macOS by default since 3.8, and Linux since 3.14 made `forkserver` its default), otherwise each worker would re-run the script.

How it works

- `python -m package.module` runs a module found via `sys.path` as `__main__` — the right way to run code inside packages, and how many tools are invoked: `python -m pip`, `python -m venv`, `python -m pytest`, `python -m http.server`, `python -m json.tool`.
- `python -m package` runs `package/__main__.py` (our demo: `python -m shop says: 19.99 -> 21.59`).
- In a script, `sys.path[0]` is the script's folder; with `-m`, it's the current directory.

```
python -m shop          ->
  [running shop/__init__.py, __name__='shop']
  python -m shop says: 19.99 -> 21.59
```

Common mistakes

- Top-level test calls or `print`s without the guard — they run every time someone imports your module.
- Putting lots of logic *inside* the guard. Keep it to `main()` so the logic stays importable and testable.

In the interview

30-second answer: "`__name__` is `'__main__'` for the file being run and the module name when imported. The guard keeps script-only code from running on import. `python -m pkg.mod` runs a

module inside a package with correct imports; `python -m pkg` runs `pkg/__main__.py`."

Self-check

1. What's `__name__` inside `shop/pricing.py` when imported? → `'shop.pricing'`.
2. What does `python -m shop` execute? → `shop/__main__.py`.

TL;DR

Guard script behaviour with `if __name__ == "__main__": main()`. Use `python -m` for modules inside packages.

8.6 Common import errors and circular imports

What it is

Most import problems fall into a handful of patterns. `03_import_errors.py` reproduces each one in a throwaway folder:

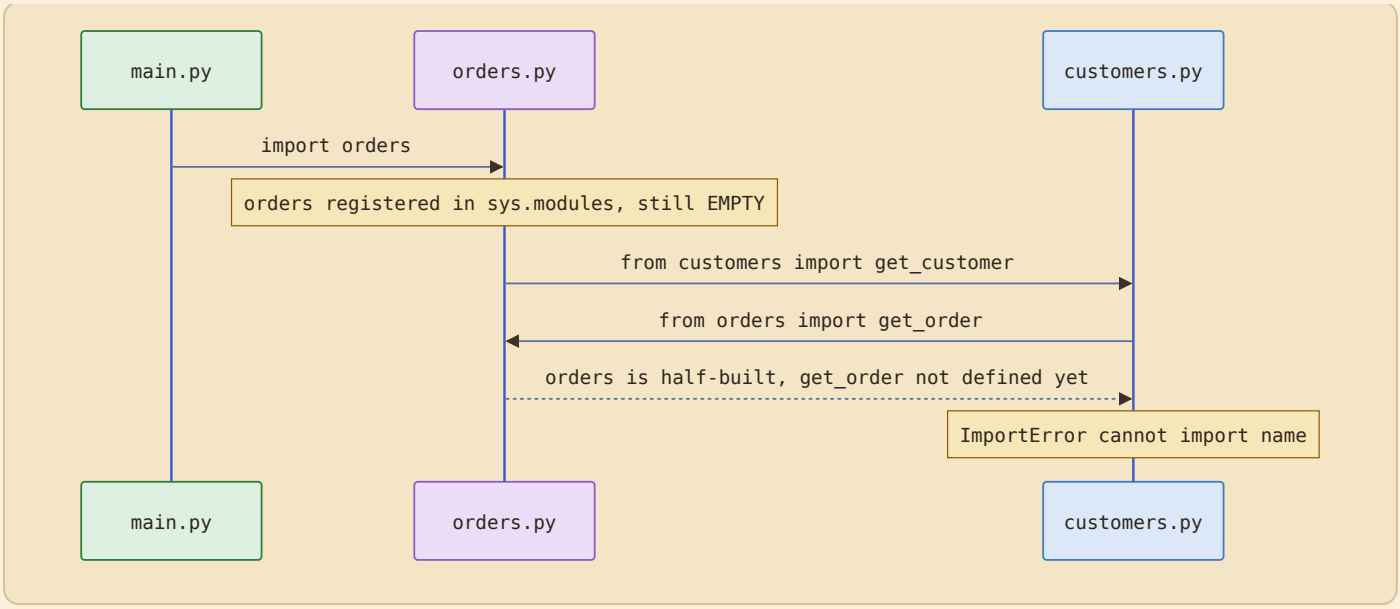
```
1. missing module                -> ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'reqests'
2. name not in module            -> ImportError: cannot import name 'square_root' from 'math'
(.../math.cpython-314-darwin.so)
3. shadowing the stdlib          -> AttributeError: module 'random' has no attribute 'randint'
(consider renaming '.../random.py' since it has the same name as the standard library module named
'random' and prevents importing that standard library module)
4. circular import (from-import) -> ImportError: cannot import name 'get_order' from 'orders'
(consider renaming '.../orders.py' if it has the same name as a library you intended to import)
4b. fixed: import module, use attr -> {'id': 7, 'customer': {'id': 1}}
4c. fixed: import inside function  -> {'id': 7, 'customer': {'id': 1}}
```

Error	Usual cause	Fix
`ModuleNotFoundError` (subclass of `ImportError`)	Typo; package not installed **in the interpreter you're running**; wrong working directory	Check spelling; `python -m pip install x` with the same `python`; install the project or use `-m`
`ImportError: cannot import name`	Name doesn't exist in that module (typo, removed in a new version) — or a circular import	Check the module's contents / version
`AttributeError: module 'x' has no attribute 'y'`	Your file named `x.py` shadows the real module; or submodule not imported	Rename your file (and delete its `__pycache__`)
`ImportError: attempted relative import …`	Ran a package module as a script	`python -m pkg.mod`

Case 3 happens because `sys.path[0]` (the script's folder) is searched before the standard library, so a local `random.py` wins. Python 3.13+ adds the helpful "consider renaming" hint.

Circular imports

A **circular import** is when module A imports B while B (directly or indirectly) imports A.



Why it breaks: step 4 of 8.2 — a module is registered in `sys.modules` *before* its body runs. When `customers` asks for `orders.get_order`, it gets the half-initialised `orders` module whose `def get_order` line hasn't executed yet. (On Python 3.12 the message says it plainly: "cannot import name 'get_order' from partially initialized module 'orders' (most likely due to a circular import)". The 3.14 run above instead appends a generic "consider renaming" hint, which is misleading here — nothing is shadowed. When you see `cannot import name` for a name that clearly exists, suspect a cycle first.)

Fixes, best first:

1. **Restructure** — move the shared code into a third module both can import (breaks the cycle; usually the right design fix).
2. **Import the module, not the name** (`import orders` then `orders.get_order(...)` inside functions) — the attribute is looked up at *call* time, after both modules have finished loading (case 4b).
3. **Deferred import** inside the function that needs it (case 4c) — cheap, local, but hides a dependency.
4. For imports needed only by type hints: `from typing import TYPE_CHECKING` / `if TYPE_CHECKING: from orders import Order` (type checkers see it, runtime doesn't).

Common mistakes

- "`pip install` worked but import fails": pip installed into a different interpreter. Always use `python -m pip ...` with the same `python` that runs your code, and check `which python` / `sys.executable`.
- Naming a file `test.py`, `code.py`, `email.py`, `random.py`, `numpy.py` …

Real-world examples

Django models in different apps that reference each other avoid circular imports by using string references (`models.ForeignKey("customers.Customer", ...)`) — a framework-level version of "look it up later".

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A circular import happens because a module is put in `sys.modules` before its body finishes, so the other module sees a half-built object and `from x import y` fails. Fix by moving shared code to a third module, importing the module instead of names so lookup happens at call time, or deferring the import into a function."

- *`ModuleNotFoundError` but the package is installed — why?* → Different interpreter/venv from the one pip used; or a local file shadows it.
- *Why does `import a` survive a cycle when `from a import f` doesn't?* → `import a` only needs the module object to exist; `from a import f` needs `f` to be defined already.

Self-check

1. What's the parent class of `ModuleNotFoundError`? → `ImportError`.
2. Why does a local `random.py` break `import random`? → The script's folder is first on `sys.path`.
3. Best long-term fix for a cycle? → Extract the shared code into a separate module.

TL;DR

Check spelling, interpreter and shadowing first. Cycles break `from x import y`; fix by restructuring, `import module`, or deferred import.

8.7 `pip` and virtual environments

What it is

- **PyPI** (Python Package Index, pypi.org) is the public repository of third-party packages.
- `pip` is the standard installer: it downloads packages (preferably pre-built **wheels**, `.whl`) and their dependencies from PyPI into an environment's `site-packages`.
- A **virtual environment (venv)** is an isolated folder containing its own `site-packages` and a `python` link to a base interpreter. Packages installed into it don't affect other projects or the system Python.

Analogy: each project gets its own toolbox; you don't throw all tools from all jobs into one drawer.

Why it matters

Project A needs `Django 4.2`, project B needs `Django 5.1` — only one can live in a single `site-packages`. Venvs give each project its own versions, make "works on my machine" reproducible, and keep you from breaking your operating system's Python. Many systems (Homebrew Python, Debian/Ubuntu) now **refuse** a global `pip install` with an `externally-managed-environment` error (PEP 668) precisely to push you into a venv.

How it works

```
python3 -m venv .venv                 # create (folder name .venv is the convention)
source .venv/bin/activate             # macOS/Linux   (Windows: .venv\Scripts\activate)
python -m pip install requests        # install into THIS venv
python -m pip install "django>=5,<6"  # version specifiers
python -m pip list                    # what's installed
python -m pip show requests           # details, dependencies
python -m pip install -U requests     # upgrade
python -m pip uninstall requests
python -m pip freeze > requirements.txt   # exact versions of everything installed
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt # recreate elsewhere
deactivate                            # leave the venv
```

"Activating" only prepends the venv's `bin/` to your `PATH` so `python` and `pip` refer to the venv's copies — you can also skip activation and call `.venv/bin/python` directly. A venv is **not portable**: don't copy or commit it; commit the dependency list and recreate it. Add `.venv/` to `.gitignore`.

Inside a venv, `sys.prefix` (the venv) differs from `sys.base_prefix` (the base install) — that's how code detects one:

```
def in_venv() -> bool:
    return sys.prefix != sys.base_prefix

venv.create(env_dir, with_pip=False)   # same as: python -m venv .venv --without-pip
```

```
== which interpreter am I? ==
  Python 3.14.7
  running inside a venv: True
  sys.prefix folder name: .venv-books

== installed distributions (importlib.metadata) ==
  numpy         2.5.3
  pandas        3.0.6
  scikit-learn  1.9.1
  numpy requires python: >=3.12

== a fresh, empty venv is isolated ==
  created: ['bin', 'include', 'lib', 'pyvenv.cfg']
  new venv -> in venv: True
  new venv -> No module named 'numpy'
```

The book's own environment has NumPy, but a brand-new venv can't see it — isolation in action. `importlib.metadata.version("numpy")` reads an installed distribution's version at runtime.

Trade-offs

Tool	What it isolates	Notes
`venv` (stdlib)	Python packages	Built in; uses an existing Python
`pipx`	Each CLI *tool* in its own venv	For tools like `black`, `httpie`, not project libraries
`conda`	Packages **and** non-Python libraries (CUDA, MKL, compilers), Python itself	Popular in data science; own package channels
Docker	Whole OS userland	Deployment-level isolation, heavier

When not to use it

You don't need a venv to run a script that uses only the standard library. Everything else — use one per project.

Common mistakes

- `pip install` running a different Python than your code → always `python -m pip`.
- `sudo pip install` into the system Python.
- Committing `.venv/` to git or copying it between machines.
- Unpinned installs in production (`pip install requests` today and next year give different versions).

Real-world examples

CI pipelines (GitHub Actions) create a fresh environment per run and install from a lock/requirements file, so every build is reproducible. Heroku-style platforms and many Docker

images do `pip install -r requirements.txt` at build time.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "pip installs packages from PyPI into an environment's site-packages. A venv is an isolated environment per project — `python -m venv .venv`, activate, `python -m pip install`. It prevents version conflicts between projects and protects the system Python. Don't commit the venv; commit the dependency list."

- *How can code tell it's in a venv?* → `sys.prefix != sys.base_prefix`.
- *venv vs conda?* → venv isolates Python packages for an existing interpreter; conda also manages Python versions and native libraries.

Self-check

1. Command to create a venv? → `python -m venv .venv`.
2. Why `python -m pip` instead of `pip`? → Guarantees pip installs into the same interpreter you run.
3. What does activating a venv actually change? → Your `PATH` (plus the prompt).

TL;DR

One venv per project. `python -m venv .venv` → activate → `python -m pip install …`. Never commit the venv.

8.8 `requirements.txt` vs `pyproject.toml`; `uv` and Poetry

What it is

- **`requirements.txt`** — a plain list of packages for pip to install, often with exact pins (`requests==2.32.3`). It describes an *environment*, not a project, and it's pip-specific.
- **`pyproject.toml`** — the standard project configuration file (TOML format). It declares **build requirements** (PEP 518, `[build-system]`), **project metadata** — name, version, supported Python, dependencies, optional extras, command-line entry points (PEP 621, `[project]`) — and settings for tools (`[tool.ruff]`, `[tool.pytest.ini_options]`, …).
- A **lock file** (`uv.lock`, `poetry.lock`, or a fully pinned requirements file) records the exact resolved version of *every* package including transitive dependencies, for reproducible installs.

How it works

A minimal `pyproject.toml` — the script parses this very text with the standard-library `tomllib` (3.11+):

```toml
[build-system]
requires = ["hatchling"]
build-backend = "hatchling.build"

[project]
name = "shop"
version = "0.1.0"
requires-python = ">=3.12"
dependencies = ["requests>=2.31,<3", "pydantic>=2"]

[project.optional-dependencies]
dev = ["pytest>=8", "ruff"]

[project.scripts]
shop = "shop.cli:main"
```

```
== reading pyproject.toml (tomllib, 3.11+) ==
  name/version : shop 0.1.0
  dependencies : ['requests>=2.31,<3', 'pydantic>=2']
  dev extras   : ['pytest>=8', 'ruff']
  console script 'shop' -> shop.cli:main
  build backend: hatchling.build
```

- `dependencies` uses **ranges** (what your code is compatible with); the lock file holds **exact pins** (what you tested).
- `pip install -e ".[dev]"` installs the project in **editable** mode plus the `dev` extras.
- `[project.scripts]` makes `pip` create a `shop` command that calls `shop.cli:main()`.
- The **build backend** (hatchling, setuptools, flit-core, poetry-core, uv_build…) turns the project into distributable files (PEP 517).

	requirements.txt	pyproject.toml
Standard?	pip convention	PEP 518/517/621 standard
Describes	An environment to install	A project: metadata, deps, build, tool config
Typical content	Exact pins	Compatible ranges
Used by	`pip install -r`	pip, build, uv, Poetry, hatch, ruff, pytest…
Best for	Deploying an app; simple scripts	Any package or modern project

Version specifiers: `==2.1.0` exact, `>=2.1` minimum, `<3` upper bound, `~=2.1` "compatible release" (≥2.1, <3.0), `!=2.1.3` exclude.

Modern tools: `uv` and Poetry (brief)

- **uv** (by Astral, written in Rust) — a very fast replacement for pip, venv, pip-tools and pipx in one binary. `uv init` (new project with `pyproject.toml`), `uv add requests` (add dependency + update `uv.lock` + install), `uv sync` (make `.venv` match the lock), `uv run pytest` (run inside the project env), `uv python install 3.12` (manage Python versions), `uv pip install ...` (pip-compatible interface), `uv build` / `uv publish`.
- **Poetry** — an older, widely used all-in-one tool: `poetry new`, `poetry add`, `poetry install`, `poetry.lock`, `poetry build`, `poetry publish`. Poetry 2.x supports the standard `[project]` table.

Both do the same core job: manage `pyproject.toml`, resolve dependencies, write a lock file, and create the venv for you.

When not to use it

For a one-file script, a venv + `requirements.txt` is enough. Don't mix tools in one project (e.g. Poetry lock + hand-edited requirements) — pick one source of truth.

Common mistakes

- Pinning exact versions in a **library's** `dependencies` — it makes your library impossible to install alongside others. Libraries use ranges; applications lock.
- `pip freeze` into requirements for a library (captures your whole environment, including dev tools).
- Forgetting to commit the lock file for applications.

Real-world examples

Most major projects (pandas, FastAPI, pytest, scikit-learn) now declare metadata in `pyproject.toml`. Tools such as ruff, black, mypy and pytest read their configuration from it.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "`requirements.txt` is a pip input listing packages, usually pinned — an environment snapshot. `pyproject.toml` is the standard project file: build system, metadata, dependency ranges, extras, entry points and tool config. Reproducibility comes from a lock file; tools like uv and Poetry manage the pyproject, lock and venv together."

- *Library vs application dependencies?* → Libraries declare loose ranges; applications pin exact versions with a lock file.
- *What's a wheel?* → A pre-built distribution (`.whl`, a zip) that installs without running a build — fast and no compiler needed.

Self-check

1. Which PEP defines the `[project]` table? → PEP 621.
2. What does `~=2.1` allow? → ≥2.1 and <3.0.
3. What file makes installs reproducible? → A lock file (or fully pinned requirements).

TL;DR

`pyproject.toml` = the project (ranges, metadata, build, tool config). Lock file / pinned `requirements.txt` = exact environment. uv (fast, all-in-one) and Poetry manage both.

8.9 Project layout and publishing basics

What it is

The **src layout** puts your package inside a `src/` folder instead of at the project root:

```
shop-project/
├── pyproject.toml
├── README.md
├── src/
│   └── shop/
│       ├── __init__.py
│       ├── __main__.py
│       ├── cli.py
│       └── pricing.py
└── tests/
    └── test_pricing.py
```

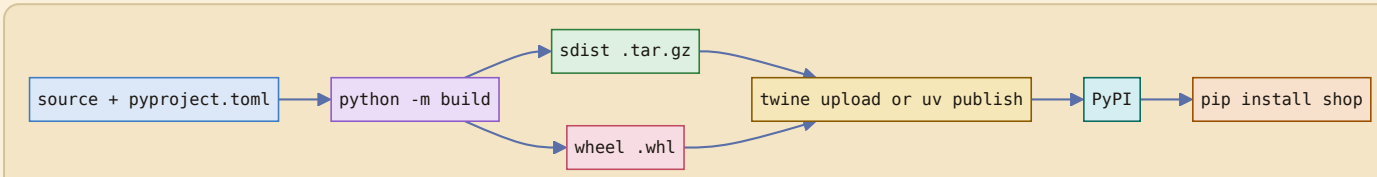
(The alternative, **flat layout**, puts `shop/` next to `pyproject.toml`.)

Why it matters

With a flat layout, running `pytest` or `python` from the project root puts the root on `sys.path`, so `import shop` silently uses your *source folder* — tests pass even if packaging is broken (a missing file in the built wheel, a wrong `package-data` rule). With the src layout, `shop` is importable **only after installing** it (`pip install -e .` for development), so your tests exercise what users actually get. The Python Packaging User Guide describes both and explains this advantage of src.

How it works — publishing to PyPI

1. Put metadata in `pyproject.toml` (name must be unique on PyPI; bump `version` for every release — PyPI never lets you re-upload a version).
2. **Build** distributions: `python -m build` (or `uv build`) creates `dist/shop-0.1.0.tar.gz` (**sdist**, source) and `dist/shop-0.1.0-py3-none-any.whl` (**wheel**, ready to install).
3. **Test** on **TestPyPI** (test.pypi.org), a separate sandbox index.
4. **Upload**: `python -m twine upload dist/*` (or `uv publish`) with an API token — or, better, **Trusted Publishing** from CI (GitHub Actions authenticates to PyPI via OpenID Connect, no long-lived token stored).
5. Users run `pip install shop`.



Trade-offs

	src layout	flat layout
Catches packaging mistakes	Yes (must install to import)	No
Setup effort	Needs `pip install -e .`	Works from root immediately
Used by	Many libraries (and uv's `--package`/`--lib` templates)	Many apps and simple projects

When not to use it

A small app that's never packaged (a Django site, a notebook project) gains little from src layout or publishing.

Common mistakes

- Uploading secrets: check `dist/` contents before uploading (a wheel is just a zip — `unzip -l`).
- Re-using a version number — PyPI will reject it.
- Package name on PyPI ≠ import name (e.g. install `scikit-learn`, import `sklearn`; install `Pillow`, import `PIL`) — confusing for users, so keep them aligned for new projects.

Real-world examples

The `pip install scikit-learn` → `import sklearn` split is the classic name mismatch. Many popular projects publish to PyPI from GitHub Actions using Trusted Publishing.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Use a `pyproject.toml`, ideally a src layout so tests run against the installed package. Build an sdist and a wheel with `python -m build` or `uv build`, try them on TestPyPI, then upload with twine or `uv publish`, preferably via Trusted Publishing from CI. Versions are immutable on PyPI."

- *sdist vs wheel?* → sdist is source that must be built on install; wheel is pre-built and installs by unpacking.
- *Why src layout?* → Prevents accidentally importing the working copy instead of the installed package.

Self-check

1. What two files does `python -m build` produce? → An sdist (`.tar.gz`) and a wheel (`.whl`).
2. How do you make a src-layout package importable while developing? → `pip install -e .` (editable install).
3. Can you re-upload version 0.1.0 after a fix? → No — release 0.1.1.

TL;DR

src layout + `pyproject.toml` + editable install for dev. `build` → sdist + wheel → TestPyPI → PyPI (Trusted Publishing).

Chapter TL;DR

- **Module** = a `.py` file; **package** = folder of modules (`__init__.py` → regular, none → namespace). `import m`, `from m import x`, `as` aliases; avoid `import *`.
- `import` checks `sys.modules` → finds via `sys.path` (script dir, PYTHONPATH, stdlib, site-packages) → registers then runs the module **once** → binds names.
- Absolute imports by default; relative (`.`) only inside packages; run package modules with `python -m`.
- `if __name__ == "__main__": main()` separates "run" from "import".
- Import errors: typo / wrong interpreter / shadowing file / circular import (module registered before its body runs — restructure, `import module`, or deferred import).
- One **venv** per project; `python -m pip`; never commit `.venv`.
- `pyproject.toml` (standard: metadata, dependency ranges, build, tool config) vs `requirements.txt` (pip list, pins); lock files for reproducibility; **uv** or **Poetry** manage it all.
- **src layout**, build **sdist + wheel**, TestPyPI, then PyPI via twine/`uv publish`/Trusted Publishing.